INNOVATION MANAGEMENT

Capsule 4

Innovation is not only technological

Another characteristic of innovation, and an important one to understand properly: innovation is not solely a technological matter.

Take the example of Apple. When we think of the iPhone or the iPod, we immediately think of a technological feat. But is that really Apple's innovation? Not only. There is design, of course, which is not a scientific matter in itself. There is marketing, the way Apple has staged its products, notably at its famous autumn keynotes. And above all, there is the business model: with the App Store and iTunes, Apple does not merely sell a device; the company also controls the entire distribution channel for the apps and music that go through that device. That is where innovation plays out, as much as in the technology itself.

Even in a sector we might think of as purely technological, such as solar panels, there is much more at stake than the performance of photovoltaic cells. There are environmental factors, the fight against global warming. Political factors: not all governments care about it to the same degree. Social factors: acceptability, a bit like wind turbines, which are sometimes criticised on aesthetic grounds. Economic factors, such as the price at which an electricity supplier buys back the surplus produced. And even geopolitical factors, linked to access to the mineral resources needed for manufacturing, or to the price of hydrocarbons, which are an alternative to electricity.

So remember this: even when an innovation has a strong technological dimension, having the best technology is never enough. You need to understand the whole environment – market, society, politics – to make it succeed.

English translation of the French script reviewed and approved by the instructor (September 2026). In the video, the image and voice are generated by an AI avatar of the instructor.